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on behalf of Mr. Tom Fletcher, Under-Secretary-General for Humanitarian Affairs and
Emergency Relief Coordinator**

Briefing to the Security Council on the humanitarian situation in Ukraine

New York, 9 July 2026

[As delivered]

Mr. President, Excellencies,

Building on the political and security developments outlined by [United Nations Under-Secretary-General for Political and Peacebuilding Affairs, Rosemary Di Carlo], allow me to focus on the impact of the latest hostilities on civilians in this armed conflict.

The past week has brought another surge of civilian casualties and suffering as outlined by USG Di Carlo. And since last Friday, attacks across Ukraine have killed and injured hundreds of civilians. Families with children have been killed in their homes, civilians injured on their way to work, and cut off from essential services.

The scale and intensity of hostilities in major urban centres in Ukraine – Dnipro, Kyiv, Kharkiv, Kherson, Sumy and Zaporizhzhia – are exacting a deeply alarming human toll.

Recent strikes in Kyiv are a stark reminder that this war continues to reach ever deeper into civilian life, damaging homes, schools and public services. For thousands of civilians, this harm is life-changing and long-lasting.

Beyond the major cities, front-line communities live under the constant threat posed by hostilities, as do civilians living in areas occupied by the Russian Federation.

Each day brings new civilian deaths and injuries, further displacement and renewed disruption of electricity, water, sewage and other services essential for survival.

Mr. President,

In the Russian Federation, we also remain concerned by reports of civilian harm and damage to infrastructure. The absence of a United Nations monitoring presence does not diminish the seriousness of these reports.

Mr. President,

As the fighting intensifies, opportunities to reach civilians safely are narrowing. For example, in parts of Donetsk region, humanitarian access has been intermittently suspended, making it harder for humanitarians to help civilians leave these areas and for humanitarian relief to reach those who remain.

International humanitarian law binds all parties to this armed conflict, wherever they carry out military operations. The parties must apply it in good faith and maximize the protection of civilians and the vital infrastructure on which they depend.

Mr. President,

Humanitarian partners continue to respond rapidly with emergency shelter, cash assistance, protection services and psychosocial support wherever they can. But the operating environment is becoming increasingly unpredictable and volatile as the evolving tactics of warfare change the risks faced by civilians, including humanitarian workers.

As the civilian toll of hostilities expands in scale and geography, humanitarian organisations are responding simultaneously to multiple emergencies while sustaining assistance to communities already enduring years of conflict.

The dangers of delivering that assistance continue to increase.

Just last week, a humanitarian convoy was struck by a drone in Ukraine-controlled Dnipro region, the third such incident in two months. Attacks also damaged a Ukrainian Red Cross warehouse, destroying humanitarian supplies intended for civilians.

Overall, attacks harming humanitarian personnel and damaging their assets have increased by more than 20 per cent compared with the same period last year.

Mr. President,

Every attack denies civilians the humanitarian assistance that they need to survive. Humanitarian personnel and assets must be protected. Rapid and unimpeded passage of humanitarian relief for civilians in need must be facilitated. International humanitarian law requires it.

Mr. President,

The scope for practical humanitarian engagement is still there, and it can save lives.

The United Nations Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs remains ready to support practical arrangements that enable the delivery of aid to those who need it, and safe, voluntary civilian evacuations from areas of hostilities, wherever they are or may choose to go.

Mr. President,

Humanitarian organisations can only respond at the required pace and scale if they are able to remain present and safe to deliver.

That requires protection for humanitarian personnel and assets, safe and sustained access, and practical arrangements to facilitate humanitarian action.

It also requires sustained and flexible funding.

Without these elements, the reach of humanitarian organisations continues to contract while the needs of civilians continue to expand.

Mr. President,

The imperatives are clear.

All States must use their influence to ensure respect for international humanitarian law. This means protecting civilians, including humanitarians, as well as critical infrastructure. It means ensuring that humanitarian organisations have unimpeded access to communities in need, wherever they are.

Through engagement with both sides, practical arrangements can and must be put in place.

Mr. President,

Whatever the pace of political efforts, civilians cannot wait. Their needs are immediate and growing. They need protection and assistance now.

I urge members of this Council to use their influence to pursue every practical opportunity to prevent further civilian suffering.

Thank you.